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Last week: **DJIA** 48134.89 ▼ 323.16 0.67% **NASDAQ** 23307.62 ▲ 0.5% **STOXX 600** 587.50 ▲ 1.6% **10-YR. TREASURY** ▲ 11/32, yield 4.150% **OIL** \$56.66 ▼ \$0.78 **EURO** \$1.1710 **YEN** 157.75

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **A contest for the nod** to become the next Fed chair is playing out in Washington and the financial sector, with industry players and Trump allies taking sides and the candidates themselves jockeying for position. **A2**

◆ **Cleveland Fed President** Beth Hammack said she sees no need to change interest rates for several months after the central bank cut rates at its last three meetings. **A2**

◆ **Mortgage rates** have fallen to their lowest level in a year, but millions of homeowners are still locked into ultralow home-loan rates they are loath to give up. **A1**

◆ **Robotics guru** Sterling Anderson, who took a job at General Motors this summer, is seen by senior GM leaders as a dark-horse candidate to succeed Chief Executive Mary Barra. **B1**

◆ **The third "Avatar"** movie had a slower start at the box office than its predecessor, setting up a long path for it to become another blockbuster by the franchise's standards. **B2**

◆ **Shein scored a win** when a Paris court rejected a French government request to suspend the e-commerce platform over the sale of contentious products. **B3**

◆ **Volkswagen will halt** exports of its retro minibus to the U.S. after the expiration of tax incentives discouraged customers from buying electric vehicles. **B3**

◆ **A Canadian hedge-fund** made one of the most-lucrative bets on artificial-intelligence stocks this year by buying unglamorous suppliers of hard-disk and flash-memory drives. **B1**

World-Wide

◆ **The U.S. oil blockade** of Venezuela is causing hardship in Cuba, which has been kept economically afloat with cheap fuel supplied by the Maduro government. **A1, A7**

◆ **The U.S. Coast Guard** is pursuing a tanker involved in carrying oil from Venezuela, part of an accelerating Trump effort to block ships from moving the country's crude. **A7**

◆ **FAA documents show** that the explosion of a SpaceX rocket in January posed a greater danger to planes in the air than was publicly known. **A1**

◆ **A Justice Department** official said the agency temporarily removed some newly public Epstein files to address victim complaints about its failure to redact their images or information. **A4**

◆ **CBS News pulled** a planned '60 Minutes' segment on the high-security El Salvador prison where the U.S. has sent many migrants, in a last-minute decision that a correspondent criticized. **A3**

◆ **Heavy U.S. strikes** against the Islamic State highlight the difficulty in fully suppressing a foe that was declared militarily defeated years ago. **A8**

◆ **California is tightening** eligibility in a pullback from its policy of enrolling immigrants living in the U.S. illegally in a Medicaid program. **A3**

◆ **Pope Leo summoned** the world's cardinals to a two-day consistory at the Vatican in January to help him govern the church. **A8**

◆ **Nine people were killed** after gunmen opened fire at a South African pub. **A8**

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Vance Rallies the Right as His Allies Look to '28



ON STAGE: Vice President JD Vance spoke Sunday at a conference of the conservative group Turning Point USA in Phoenix. Erika Kirk, the widow of the organization's slain founder, endorsed Vance for president in 2028 in her kickoff remarks. **A4**

U.S. Oil Blockade of Venezuela Pushes Cuba Toward Collapse

By JUAN FORERO AND RYAN DUBÉ

Cubans are going hungry, suffering from spreading disease and sleeping outdoors with no electricity to power fans through the sweltering nights. A quarter of the population has fled during the island's most prolonged economic crisis.

And it is about to get worse. The U.S. is ratcheting up pressure on Havana's key benefactor, Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro's regime, which has kept Communist-ruled Cuba afloat with cheap oil. Now Venezuelan oil exports are at risk because of a partial blockade targeting

sanctioned tankers—the kind that carry about 70% of the country's crude.

One tanker that the U.S. has already seized was en route with almost two million barrels of Venezuelan oil. On Saturday, U.S. forces boarded another vessel, a Panamanian-flagged oil tanker, off Venezuela.

The blockade adds to a U.S. pressure campaign on Maduro that also includes a military buildup in the Caribbean, airstrikes on boats allegedly connected to Venezuelan drug trafficking and threats of bombing the country itself.

Were Venezuela's oil shipments to stop, or sharply decline, the Cubans know it

would be devastating.

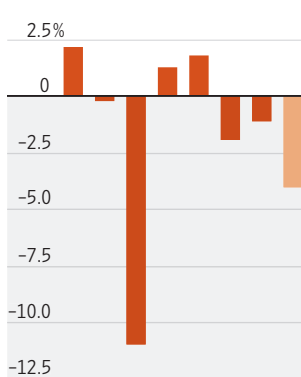
"It would be the collapse of the Cuban economy, no question about it," said Jorge Piñón, a Cuban exile who tracks the island's energy ties to Venezuela at the University of Texas at Austin.

Venezuela has been vital for Cuba's economy since 1999, when then-President Hugo Chávez described the two countries as bound together "in a sea of happiness." Cuba deployed sports trainers,

Please turn to page A7

◆ **U.S. chasing oil tanker linked to Venezuela.....** **A7**
◆ **Chevron remains largest foreign investor.....** **A7**

Cuba gross domestic product, change from previous year



*First three quarters
Sources: Cuba Study Group; Government of Cuba (2025)

29 Shots in 24 Seconds: Was It a Self-Defense Case?

A WSJ investigation of a road-rage homicide yields new clues

From the moment Scott Spivey was shot in the back on Camp Swamp Road, the killer stuck to his story, repeating an account that has kept Weldon Boyd a free man.

By Valerie Bauerlein, Brenna T. Smith, Cam Pollack and Peter Champelli

"He shot f—ing first," Boyd told the 911 operator. He claimed the same to witnesses who caught only glimpses of the confrontation. Boyd said it again to police, describing how Spivey had earlier tried to run him off

the road and waved a gun out the window. Boyd reacted by chasing Spivey at high speeds for nearly 9 miles before Spivey got out of his truck with a .45 caliber pistol in his hand and a belly full of beer and whiskey.

Spivey hollered at Boyd to stop following him. Then the shooting started.

No one saw who shot first, except for Boyd and his buddy, Bradley Williams. The two men fired 9mm pistols through the front windshield at Spivey, killing the 33-year-old insurance ad-

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Homeowners Won't Give Up Low Rates

By NICOLE FRIEDMAN

Mortgage rates have fallen to their lowest level in a year, but millions of homeowners are still locked into ultralow mortgage rates they don't want to give up.

Nearly 30 million households, or 54% of primary mortgage-holders, have mortgage rates at or below 4%. They were able to buy homes or refinance their mortgages when rates fell to 3% or lower in 2020 and 2021.

Now, many of those who

want to move don't feel it is worth it to buy a home and take on mortgage rates that have doubled.

This "lock-in effect" has helped freeze the housing market for three straight years, suppressing the number of U.S. homes for sale and keeping inventory well below historic levels for most of that period.

"We don't expect to see this massive influx of home buyers," *Please turn to page A2*

◆ **Cleveland Fed chief wary of rate cut.....** **A2**

A Man Tries Going Cash-Only To Cut Spending and Trim Debt

Chase Gohl had \$500 in a quest to cover food, gas and entertainment for 30 days

By JENNIFER WILLIAMS

Christmas was coming, but this goose wasn't getting fat. Chase Gohl needed to save money, so he planned an audacious challenge: Spend just \$500 on entertainment, food and gas for a month. Cash only.

In October, the 32-year-old market professional had spent \$1,800 on eating and outings. The month before, \$1,870. He hadn't spent less than \$985 all year.

Still, November felt like the time to try. The holidays are expensive, with gift buying, socializing and travel. As

Americans look for ways to stretch their dollar, more are heading to the ATM. Some keep the cash in envelopes. Gohl went with his wallet.

So-called cash stuffing surged in popularity a few years ago, with some finance experts touting a card-free existence as a top way to budget. It's picking up again: Some 48% of U.S. consumers said they expect cash to be among their top three payment methods this holiday season, according to a PricewaterhouseCoopers survey, a seven-percentage-point increase *Please turn to page A11*



Cash is king

INSIDE



JULIAN RIGGS/WSJ

JOANNA STERN

An AI vending machine dispensed pure chaos during its run in the WSJ newsroom. **A10**



GRANT HINDSLEY FOR WSJ

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Teens are creating their own AI companies—and VC investors are interested. **B1**

Health-Tracking Gifts Find Place Under Tree

By ANDREA PETERSEN AND SARA ASHLEY O'BRIEN

This Christmas, Darlene Fiske is giving her 22-year-old son a pair of cowboy boots, athletic socks—and a gut microbiome test kit that requires a DIY poop sample.

"He's super into learning about his health and his body and how it works," says Fiske, the 55-year-old owner of a public-relations firm in Austin, Texas. "I'm sure he'll be grossed out. Hopefully he'll do it and not be too embarrassed."

As wellness influencers proliferate and high sleep scores are considered status symbols, 2025 is the year of the health gift.

Among the presents family and friends will be unwrapping: microbiome tests, which detail the types of bacteria living in your gut, and ser-

vices that use continuous glucose monitoring devices, which measure blood sugar. Some will get panels of blood tests that examine everything from hormone levels to thyroid and liver function.

Kristina Velkova-Levine purchased a membership for regular lab testing, tracking and insights, for her husband. The membership, from a firm called Function Health, charges \$365 a year for two rounds of testing, and assesses hormone, metabolic and other biomarkers.

She plans to buy one for herself as well. Velkova-Levine, 34, and her husband plan to try to conceive next year. She says the results will help.

"I'll probably just print something out, and put a cute note that it's our moment to check all of our health thor- *Please turn to page A10*